

Grace Muller

Colby Gordon

Early Modern Crime

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These Dog-Days: Bosola's Perception of Prodigies in *The Duchess of Malfi*

John Webster's *The Duchess of Malfi* is a work that entrenches itself— and, truly, the courtly setting it takes place in— between the boundaries of human and nonhuman. It constantly tosses animalistic descriptions of its characters at its audience; all at once, the play becomes a zoo filled with creatures straddling the line between man and animal. Sometimes, this appears figuratively in the descriptions characters offer of themselves and each other; For example, the Duchess refers to herself in a conversation with Ferdinand as a “[bird]... that’s already flown” (3.2). Other times, however, this can be observed far more literally, such as in Ferdinand’s descent in to madness, suffering from “lycanthropy” and believing himself to be transformed into a wolf (5.2).

In the early modern period, the term that would refer to those sorts of bodies which transverse and blur these boundaries was *prodigy*. In his article “Abortive Hedgehogs: Prodigies and Trans Animality in *The Duchess of Malfi*,” Colby Gordon defines a prodigy as “a portentous event or body understood to herald death and social dissolution” (Gordon 209). The origin of the term itself goes back to the Roman Republic, and technically also includes events such as “lightning strikes on sacred ground; sweating statues; speaking animals or the incursion of wild beasts into the city of Rome; rainfalls of blood, stone, or milk; and anomalous births, particularly the birth of hermaphrodites” (Gordon 209). Especially in regards to prodigious births, these human-animal children could be seen as a punishment for or a reflection of the

actions of the mother. For example, the “monster of Ravenna,” a monster adorned with “wings, a horn, and claws while also ‘participating in the natures of both male and female,’” was reportedly the child of a nun and Pope Julius II (Gordon 209). Medieval and early modern writers were particularly inclined towards the human-animal hybrids we see causing chaos in *The Duchess of Malfi*, and they really decided to run with it (Gordon 209), writing of animals with the faces of men, men with the faces of animals, and a whole host of other anomalies (Gordon 209).

There is one character, however, who is able to see beyond these blurred, inter-species lines, thereby separating him from the rest; Bosola, a “fantastic scholar” (3.3) who, after being forced out of academia, became an assassin—a dog barking at the feet of the Cardinal. Bosola does use animal imagery to describe himself; When talking to the Cardinal, he refers to the current times as “these dog-days” (1.1), insinuating that he is acting on his master’s commands like some sort of animal. However, unlike the other characters in the court, he is able to correctly diagnose the prodigious nature of those who surround him. When venting to Antonio, he says that “[the Cardinal] and his brother are like plum-trees that grow crooked over standing-pools; they are rich and o’erladen with fruit, but none but crows, pies, and caterpillars feed on them” (1.1). The people who run things in the court, the Cardinal and Ferdinand, are corrupt and drunk on riches and luxury, looming above everyone else as their poison permeates through everyone and everything. According to Bosola, this corruption is intricately tied with the prodigies that can be seen everywhere in *The Duchess of Malfi*; as prodigies are signs of death, social dissolution, and other harm, the prodigies in this text can be interpreted as both a sign and a result of the corruption that abounds within the court. While Bosola himself is not immune from neither this corruption nor the prodigy it brings— in fact, he tells Ferdinand that “[his] own corruption grew

out of horse dung; [He is Ferdinand's] creature" (1.3) — his position as both an outsider from beyond the court and an educated man allows him to recognize what others cannot: Bosola believes that human beings are inherently prone to corruption, and prodigy is therefore a part of human nature.

Bosola makes a very explicit reference to prodigies in Scene 2 of Act 1, after he insults an old woman for covering her face with makeup. In a sudden meditation on human nature, he says,

What thing is in this outward form of man
To be belov'd? We account it ominous,
If nature do produce a colt, or lamb,
A fawn, or goat, in any limb resembling
A man, and fly from 't as a prodigy:
Man stands amaz'd to see his deformity
In any other creature but himself.
But in our own flesh though we bear diseases
Which have their true names only ta'en from beasts,—
As the most ulcerous wolf and swinish measles,—
Though we are eaten up of lice and worms,
And though continually we bear about us
A rotten and dead body, we delight
To hide it in rich tissue: all our fear,
Nay, all our terror, is, lest our physician
Should put us in the ground to be made sweet. (2.1)

Here, Bosola tells the old woman— and us, as the audience (I personally find this monologue very much akin to a soliloquy, even if not directly addressed to the audience)— that humanity is inherently corrupt, as we are eaten up of lice and worms, the sort that feed on the corrupt fruit of men like Ferdinand and the Cardinal. Furthermore, we bear animalistic diseases such as lupus and measles (the “ulcerous wolf” and “swinish measles” which— just like the metaphor found in the various animal references throughout *The Duchess of Malfi*— can be considered prodigious as they force humans into animalistic forms through disease and therefore force us to straddle the line between human and animal. Not only must humans bear these evils, but they are what “put us in the ground to be made sweet;” We’re made sweet, in Bosola’s eyes, because the prodigy is gone, having been put away in the ground to be eaten away by the worms, beetles and bugs which permeated that human soul. The outward form of man that we insist on covering up is a form that is inherently animalistic and prone to corruption, only purified through death.

Bosola doesn’t believe that humanity’s prodigious nature only exists on the outside, however; our insides are similarly eaten at by animalistic rot. A little earlier in the conversation with that old woman, before he waxes poetic on man’s inherently prodigious form, Bosola says that,

Why, from your scurvy face-physic. To behold thee not
 painted inclines somewhat near a miracle. These in thy face here
 were deep ruts and foul sloughs the last progress. There was
 a lady in France that, having had the small-pox, flayed the skin off
 her face to make it more level; and whereas before she looked
 like a nutmeg-grater, after she resembled an abortive hedge-hog. (2.1)

Bosola's choice of words in his comparison between this French woman and an "abortive hedgehog" conveys his belief that humanity's prodigious nature also comes from deep within; she carved away a human (albeit ugly, I suppose, according to Bosola) exterior in order to reveal a horrific, animalistic, hedgehog-like interior within. In peeling back her flesh, she has revealed the awful, gory, bloody truth underneath. This woman's actions can also, in a sense be viewed as an attempt to cover up her true nature. In shaving away her small-pox ridden skin— which can perhaps be seen as a "beastlike" disease that distorts the form of the human body such as lupus and measles— and making an effort to make her face appear more level, beautiful, and "perfect," she only ends up revealing her true nature underneath. In saying this, Bosola shows us how he believes that prodigy is a disease that lingers in every bit of the human body, inside and out.

The play itself initially appears to prove Bosola right in what he's been saying; throughout the remainder of *The Duchess of Malfi*, the court devolves into death upon death brought on by its inhabitants' own corruption. By the end of the play, the dead include The Cardinal, Ferdinand, Antonio, the Duchess, Cariola, Julia and even Bosola himself. These deaths are all a result of the corrupt— Ferdinand and the Cardinal are killed by Bosola, who as we know is full of dung-grown corruption (5.5); Similarly, Antonio and Julia are also killed by Bosola (5.5); and the deaths of Cariola and the Duchess are arranged by the "Arragonian bretheren" (5.5), Ferdinand and the Cardinal. All of this death and chaos occur due to the corrupt forces that permeate the text, therefore supporting Bosola's view of humanity as inherently prodigious, as the prodigies he sees everywhere he looks are a signal of the corruption. Thesis:

This very pessimistic view that Bosola holds is again driven home by what he says as he dies. As Bosola begins to succumb to the death-wound he sustained in the fight in which he killed both Ferdinand and the Cardinal, he cries out, saying,

O, this gloomy world!

In what a shadow, or deep pit of darkness,

Doth womanish and fearful mankind live!

Let worthy minds ne'er stagger in distrust

To suffer death or shame for what is just:

Mine is another voyage. (5.5)

As a part of his final words, Bosola insults all of mankind (albeit with a misogynistic layer to it), which is consistent with his fairly negative few of humanity up to this point. Despite Bosola's beliefs and actions, I personally can't help but pity him in this moment. His entire story is a little pitiable; He didn't exactly plan to leave academia— nor did he necessarily set out to become an assassin, rather the situation was a bit thrust upon him by circumstance (as a perspective academic who's going to enter the current job market, I am compelled to feel sympathetic, as well as just a bit worried). In some ways, it's a desperate situation that many, including myself, can relate to. It appears that this life of his, in which he has essentially seen his dreams crushed, and has had to witness the evil of his fellow man every day (as I can imagine comes frequently with the job of an assassin), has shaped his worldview into one of pessimism and inherent malice.

However, this worldview of Bosola's is one that is in fact challenged in the end of the play itself. After the carnage has ended, and those that were dying are now dead, Delio arrives

with the Duchess and Antonio's eldest— and only surviving— child. In the final words of the play, he says to the survivors,

Let us make noble use
 Of this great ruin; and join all our force
 To establish this young hopeful gentleman
 In 's mother's right. These wretched eminent things
 Leave no more fame behind 'em, than should one
 Fall in a frost, and leave his print in snow;
 As soon as the sun shines, it ever melts,
 Both form and matter. I have ever thought
 Nature doth nothing so great for great men
 As when she 's pleas'd to make them lords of truth:
 Integrity of life is fame's best friend,
 Which nobly, beyond death, shall crown the end. (5.5)

Delio appears to have a view of the world that is extremely different from Bosola's. He believes that nobility can come out of the extreme chaos that just occurred, and that the things of the past will stay in the past. This son of Antonio and the Duchess is, according to Delio, going to have a good, hopeful life. Perhaps the point of Delio's that sticks out the most is how he talks about nature. To Bosola, the natural world brings about these prodigious indicators of death and destruction in the bodies of every man, as while prodigies are indeed heralds of ruin, they also serve as evidence of the frightening might and power of nature. Gordon writes that "Although popular print culture

often framed prodigies as signals of providential displeasure with political or social affairs, the problem with such bodies was not that they were unnatural. Indeed, from the perspective of an emerging natural philosophy, prodigies gestured toward the ‘inexhaustibly fecund and varied’ capacities of the natural world” (Gordon 209). Opposed to Bosola, Delio believes that nature makes men “lords of truth,” rather than twisting them into horrific, animalistic forms via abomination and disease; Integrity of life and nobility will be his future, rather than the dirt with its words and bugs.

The Duchess of Malfi as a play appears to endorse Delio’s view of the world, rather than Bosola’s. For one, Delio’s monologue is the very end of the play, and he therefore has the final word; the text itself doesn’t leave any more space for a counter argument in favor of the prodigious nature of man. Additionally, all of the characters that showcase this evil that Bosola sees in everyone die terrible, painful deaths. Even some of the more morally “good” characters are associated with and tainted by prodigies in some way due to their association with the court, such as the Duchess— who, as mentioned previously, is associated with bird imagery— and even her two other children, who are referred to as “young wolves” (4.2) by Ferdinand are killed. However, her surviving son, who was away from court and therefore is able to avoid being tainted by its animalistic corruption, is one of the only characters to have anything close to a hopeful ending (as hopeful as it can be, really, when your entire family has just been slaughtered. He is also described as a “pretty gentleman” (5.5) by Pescara, implying that he is devoid of any abominable traits and free of any prodigious maladies. The text rewards the character who is perhaps most removed from prodigies with a happier ending, while the rest of the characters are killed, therefore pushing the more optimistic narrative.

While Bosola unfortunately— or, perhaps fortunately, depending on what you make of him— fails to survive the events of *The Duchess of Malfi*, his philosophy serves to shape the play as a whole. Through Bosola, we as an audience are able to view the corruption of the court and the true animalistic nature that lies beneath the surface of many of its characters. Perhaps it is a good thing that hope appears to have triumphed in the end; While it is important to be able to recognize the evil qualities of those around you, it is equally as important to not let them consume your entire world, especially in times of hardship. Bosola was ultimately consumed by corrupting fruit of those horrible plum trees— which, given his circumstances, feels as though it was inevitable— even becoming an integral part of their evil deeds himself, which eventually led to his death. In order to live, we must be able to make noble use of our great ruin, instead of perpetuating that cycle. In any case, Bosola's dog-days are over; in his death, it has become time for him to give up that rotten and dead body, being put in the ground to remain sweet.

Works Cited

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